



# Financial Aid Offer Decoder

Separate free aid, work, loans, and the amount your family must actually cover.

**MADE FOR**

Students and families comparing college offers

Use this toolkit as a planning guide. Requirements, deadlines, and availability are set by each school, scholarship, agency, or provider. EFF cannot guarantee funding or outside assistance.

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## Label every line

| Category              | What it means                                                        |
|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Grants + scholarships | Free aid unless conditions are not met                               |
| Work-study            | Wages earned through eligible employment; not an upfront bill credit |
| Federal loans         | Borrowed by the student and repaid with interest                     |
| Parent/private loans  | Borrowed separately; approval and terms vary                         |
| Estimated costs       | May include indirect costs not billed by the college                 |

## Calculate the real gap

| Item                        | Amount |
|-----------------------------|--------|
| Tuition + required fees     | \$     |
| Housing + meal plan         | \$     |
| Other direct billed costs   | \$     |
| Minus grants + scholarships | -\$    |
| Minus accepted loans        | -\$    |
| Amount still due            | \$     |

Do not subtract work-study unless you have a job and know when wages will be paid.

## Questions before accepting

- Is each scholarship renewable, and what GPA is required?
- What costs are billed directly?
- Could grants change after verification?
- How much debt would I have after four years?
- What happens if housing, enrollment, or family income changes?
- What is the graduation rate and typical time to finish?